

Chapter 1. Fog

A thick fog hung over the street, making passage difficult even in broad daylight. The station seemed especially lonely in such weather. Few travelers passed by the closed shops.

The station master sat in his office, reading an old newspaper from 1891. The world seemed vast and frightening to him. There were exactly three houses standing near the edges of the square.

As evening fell, the city sank into deep silence. Candles in windows burned dimly and flickered in the wind. No one came or left through the station.

Chapter 2. The Letter

The letter arrived at the most unexpected moment, when the station master had long stopped hoping for any news.^[1] The envelope was wrinkled and dirty, as if it had traveled long roads. The address was written in a beautiful hand, though with some errors.

The station master opened the letter with trembling hands. "You were late," said Dr. Smith in a voice that seemed to come from the past. His heart began to race. There was still too much unclear.

He understood that everything must change now. The past returned unexpectedly. The future seemed uncertain and alarming, like a fog that would not lift.

¹ Author's note: this is a fictional story.

Chapter 3. The Bridge

The bridge across the river was the only path to a new life, but the station master feared to cross it. The wooden boards creaked beneath his feet and swayed in the wind. The water below seemed infinitely deep and black, worth perhaps \$2,500 in his dreams.

He stood in the middle of the bridge, gazing at the dark horizon. Behind him lay years of doubt and failure. Ahead lay something unknown, but it no longer frightened him as it once did.

At last he stepped across the final boards. The opposite shore greeted him silently and peacefully. And he understood that the greater part of his life was behind him, but a new one was just beginning.